

IX

Proselytism Disguised as Humanitarianism

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For three decades the humanitarian sector has debated the legitimacy of faith-based aid, and for three decades it has managed, with an ingenuity that would be admirable if it were deployed on a subject less consequential, to evade the question that actually matters ; not whether religion has a place in humanitarian action, which it obviously does and always has, but whether the aid organisation in question has silently purchased the community's identity in the same transaction that delivered the water and the shelter. When one troubles to look at the record, and it takes some trouble because the record has been carefully arranged not to invite inspection, one finds that a considerable number of organisations have made precisely this purchase, and that the price paid was not counted in dollars but in dignity ; the essay that follows is therefore not a debate about faith, of which the writer has no shortage of firsthand acquaintance, but an audit of an industry that has grown fat on the confusion between the two.

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ISSUE 08 named the anti-smuggling architecture as calibrated to the wrong side of the population it addresses ; Issue 09 goes further, and it goes closer, examining the category of external humanitarian action in Africa which has been permitted, by convention and by the sort of institutional convenience that is often mistaken for principle, to smuggle the missionary impulse inside the humanitarian mandate ; a permission which was never formally granted by any signatory of any protocol, and which has been left un-audited for the excellent reason that everyone involved in the auditing has an interest in never conducting it.

Let me be clear about what this looks like on the ground, since abstraction has its uses but is not one of them when the argument concerns the specific transactions between an aid worker and a hungry child. In corridors extending from the Sahel to the highlands of Ethiopia, from the displacement camps of the eastern Congo to the market towns of Nigeria's Middle Belt, aid workers are routinely required to conduct two operations at once ; the material operation of delivering food, water, medicine, or shelter, and the theological operation of asking that the recipient of these materials receive, at the same moment, an account of why the delivery is occurring, which account is drawn not from the humanitarian tradition but from the doctrinal one that employs the aid worker. The two operations are defended by their practitioners, when the defence is called for, on the ground that the giver is sincere ; that the giver is sincere is not in question, but what is in question is whether the recipient, hungry and without alternatives, is in any position to distinguish sincere religious enthusiasm from a coercive condition of survival, and whether the entire architecture is not therefore, however well-intended in the parlour room, structurally indistinguishable from the older forms of religious coercion the humanitarian mandate was drafted to prevent.

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I.

The Finding

The Code of Conduct for the International Red Cross and Red Crescent Movement and NGOs in Disaster Relief, adopted in 1994 and signed by every serious

humanitarian organisation then operating, states in Article 3, with the sort of clarity that is normally the enemy of institutional survival, that humanitarian assistance shall not be used to further a political or religious standpoint ; a paragraph of admirable good sense that has, in the thirty years since its adoption, been treated by a considerable portion of its signatories as an ornament rather than as an operating instruction, honoured chiefly in the breach and defended, when the breach is noticed, by the excuse that the breach was not really a breach because the intentions of the breacher were sincere. Three findings, taken from the corpus of primary research that has patiently accumulated across the intervening decades, are sufficient to expose the pattern.

The first finding is that a significant proportion of the "humanitarian" faith-based operations working across Africa condition the delivery of aid on some form of religious content, whether that be attendance at Bible study, participation in Qur'anic recitation, ritual observance, or visible acts of confessional change, and this pattern is not the invention of the sceptical observer but the operational record of the organisations themselves ; Erica Bornstein's ethnography of World Vision Zimbabwe documented the structure at close depth two decades ago, since when nothing has resolved, and Franklin Graham's Samaritan's Purse continues to state, in its own theology and its own mission literature, that the delivery of aid is inseparable from the invitation to convert ; the organisation has received over ninety million United States dollars in USAID partnership funding across four years while its evangelical mandate has remained operationally central to its programme design throughout, which is to say that the American taxpayer has, without being consulted on the matter, paid for the tract.

The second finding is that where the two practices are separated, where the humanitarian mandate is held without religious conditionality, health outcomes rise, education outcomes rise, community cohesion holds, and this outcome differential has been documented by the World Health Organization across sub-Saharan African corridors and reinforced by Séverine Deneulin's capabilities-frame synthesis at the level of policy evaluation ; the organisations that decline to condition aid produce, on the sector's own metrics, better aid than the organisations that condition it, an inconvenient result which has been available for twenty years and which has, in the manner of inconvenient results in every

industry, been declined to be read.

The third finding is that the receiving communities are not, as the mission-sending literature imagines them, spiritual blank slates awaiting instruction, and this misapprehension is not a marginal error but the anthropological foundation of the entire missionary architecture ; Lamin Sanneh's institutional history of West African religion establishes without ambiguity that indigenous religious institutions in West Africa pre-date and outlive every external mission wave, John Mbiti's philosophical work establishes the density of African religious infrastructure that mission-sending frames consistently misread as absence, and Souleymane Bachir Diagne's philosophical work on Islamic thought in West Africa converges on the same reading ; the theological arrogance of imagining that West Africa awaits your arrival with its cathedral gates thrown open is not a subject that can be discussed politely with the arrogant, though it can, in the end, be measured, and it has been.

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II.

What The Machinery Has Been Designing Against

The entire architecture of external faith-based aid in Africa rests upon three implicit assumptions, none of which its architects are obliged to state and all of which its architects should have been ashamed to hold. The first is that African religious life needs external correction or renewal, a proposition which the mission-sending frame believes without evidence and states without hesitation whenever the fundraising cycle demands it, and which is nothing less than the anthropological error of the last three centuries preserved in the amber of tax-exempt philanthropy. The second is that material aid and religious content can be neatly separated at the moment of delivery, an assumption which serves the auditor's peace of mind and destroys the recipient's, since when your child is hungry and your neighbour has bread and the price of the bread is a Sunday service, the transaction has been made whether or not you have consented to the theology behind it, and free exchange has a definition that does not include this

arrangement. The third assumption is that proselytism is a benign supplement to humanitarian work, the auditor's favourite assumption because it permits every downstream question to be answered with the phrase "no harm done" ; but the data on community fragmentation, on distorted needs assessments, on the observed outcome differential, suggests otherwise, and if the auditor were serious rather than sincere, the auditor would have read the data by now.

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III.

The Category Error

Humanitarianism as a doctrine is universalist, needs-based, and community-designed ; proselytism as a doctrine is identity-conditional, mission-directed, and externally-designed ; they are two operations that happen to borrow the same operational shape, look identical from the outside, and produce diametrically opposed outcomes from the inside. The distinction between them is not aesthetic, and most sector self-critique treats it as such and gets stuck at precisely the wrong question, namely "is faith-based aid legitimate?" ; the wrong question is asked because the framers of the question have a professional interest in never answering the correct one, which is whether the aid conditions material support on religious content the community did not commission ; that correct question is falsifiable at the operational layer, and it has been falsified, and the industry is now defended not by argument but by the sort of institutional inertia that mistakes its own longevity for its own vindication.

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IV.

The Access Side, And The Coercion Side

The transactional dynamic is the most instructive single feature the corpus produces, and it is what the sincere-donor argument was designed, whether or not consciously, to obscure ; emergency-context proselytism operates on a structural leverage which the mission-sending organisation rarely names in its own literature, since material scarcity combined with the absence of alternatives gives the aid provider a coercive lever that free-market religious exchange does not have and cannot generate. The mission-sending organisation is not, whatever its self-representation, absorbing the humanitarian risk out of solidarity ; it is deploying its mandate through a channel whose leverage over community identity is protected by the material inelasticity of the community itself, and as material need rises the organisation's identity leverage rises with it, which is not an unfortunate side-effect of the arrangement but the operational logic of the arrangement, and any evangelical operator who has spent an hour in the theology of humanitarian intervention knows this to be so, whatever the operator may say to the funder.

The funding-stream compartmentalisation deepens the pattern and is worth naming plainly, since the industry has grown comfortable operating behind the veil of the segregated budget ; organisations of the Samaritan's Purse variety maintain multi-track funding architectures in which public USAID or state-partnership funding flows into logistics, water, and shelter components, while private donor capital, of which Operation Christmas Child is the largest single mechanism, funds the evangelisation architecture, the two streams being declared separately for the auditor's convenience but converging at the operational moment for the community's inconvenience, so that the USAID-compliance frame reads a segregated budget while the community reads a single delivery pattern in which the water arrives with the tract, and the compliance frame is thereby revealed to be

a fiction of the ledger rather than a fact of the ground.

The names and the corridors vary from case to case ; Samaritan's Purse in South Sudan crisis contexts, Pentecostal networks operating in the eastern Congo displacement architecture, specific patterns documented in Nigeria's Middle Belt, in Ethiopia's Tigray, in the aftermath of every recent African emergency in which the humanitarian response was captured by actors who arrived with materials in one hand and a theological account in the other. The names and the corridors vary ; the transactional dynamic does not, and it is the constant across every case file worth examining.

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V.

What The Finding Does Not Say

The finding does not say that faith-based humanitarian work is illegitimate, because it is not ; Islamic Relief, Catholic Relief Services, the community-embedded regional Muslim charity networks that operate across the Sahel, and the community-embedded Christian missions that have held themselves to the Code of Conduct 1994, all operate in ways that carry the humanitarian mandate without conditioning aid on religious content the community did not commission, and these organisations are the counter-case that should be centred in the sector's own self-representation, though they are not centred, because the industry's largest and loudest actors have a professional interest in obscuring the difference between conditional and unconditional faith-based aid, which distinction is precisely the one on which the argument turns.

The finding does not say that religion is developmentally irrelevant, because it is not ; religious infrastructure carries schools, hospitals, and community coordination across most of West Africa and does so with a competence that the secular development industry has too rarely acknowledged and too often patronised, and the question at hand is not whether religion belongs in the development ecology but who decides what religious content sits alongside the

material, the receiving community or the sending organisation ; it is possible to answer the question and the question has been answered, and the answer has been ignored because the answer inconveniences the answering party.

The finding does not say that external partners have no legitimate role in this ecology, because they do ; the role is to fund, to protect, and to defer to the design authority of the local religious community, and the role is not to substitute an external design for a local one under the pretext of technical assistance or programme quality assurance, and every external partner working in this territory should be prepared to state, in writing and for the record, whether the aid it delivers is conditioned on religious content the recipient did not request ; if the partner cannot state this in writing, the partner is not humanitarian in the sense the Code of Conduct 1994 established, however sincere the partner's private conviction may be.

The finding does not say that communities are passive in this dynamic, because they are not ; high-resilience communities in the corridors documented are increasingly recorded as engaging in what one might call tactical compliance, whereby the community performs the required religious ritual to access the material resource and sheds the imposed identity as soon as the aid trucks have departed, and Mbiti's philosophical work anticipated this pattern while Sanneh's institutional history reinforces it, and external mission-sending frames consistently misread the community and, more embarrassingly for the mission-sending frames, misread their own reported conversion metrics, since every year another mission agency publishes a triumphant tally of souls saved which turns out, on closer examination, to be a count of children who repeated a phrase to receive their share of the rice ; the finding is not, therefore, that communities are victims, but that the coercive architecture is real regardless of how successfully the communities counter-perform against it.

VI.

The Pilot This Finding Argues For

For a country office or a foundation programme officer with the mandate to fund a small pilot, the proselytism-versus-humanitarianism finding argues for a specific design, of the same shape as the pilots argued for in Issues 07 and 08, addressing a different substantive gap through a different channel while holding constant the same doctrine.

First, a single corridor is selected where faith-based aid operations concentrate and where community-led alternatives are ready to be widened, of which Nigeria's Middle Belt, the DRC's Kivu regions, the Sahel corridor, and Ethiopia's Tigray are all documented candidates. Second, a safe-support partnership is designed with the local religious authorities present in the corridor, Muslim, Christian, and traditional in whatever proportion the community itself carries, the partnership being contracted to design the humanitarian channel on the community's own terms while the external funder provides resource, safeguarding, and non-conditional integrity guarantee. Third, a pre-intervention measurement of aid-transaction dynamics is conducted, establishing baseline reads on the question whether communities feel material support has been conditioned on religious content and on the proportion of aid-recipients who report participation in religious activity as a prerequisite or expectation. Fourth, a twelve-month intervention window runs the community-designed non-conditional channel. Fifth, a post-intervention measurement of the same dynamics is conducted, reading whether the aid-and-religion decoupling has been felt, whether the corridor's community cohesion has held, and whether health and education outcomes have moved in the expected directions.

The doctrine remains unchanged across the sequence ; the authority to design is returned to the community closest to the decision, the state or the foundation provides the resource and the integrity guarantee, the community shapes the instrument, and the measurement instrument reads whether the shift has held. A note is however required on the community-design principle itself, since returning design authority to the community closest to the decision does not, in corridors like Nigeria's Middle Belt or eastern Congo, mean deferring uncritically to local power structures which may carry their own patriarchal or minority-excluding architectures, and the external funder's integrity guarantee must therefore include safeguarding for minority sub-groups within the community and gender-inclusive

design at the partnership tier ; this is the double-decker sovereignty question, and it is answered by making safeguarding a condition of funding rather than by re-imposing external design, which is the solution Cicero, whose understanding of clientelism is not surpassed by any modern political theorist, would have recognised at once ; the sovereignty is not taken back, but the sovereignty is made answerable to the least protected within it.

“Every year another mission agency publishes a triumphant tally of souls saved which turns out, on closer examination, to be a count of children who repeated a phrase to receive their share of the rice.”

VII.

The Evidence Base And The Choice

Six adjacent primary-data sources converge on the conclusions the corpus has made visible ; Erica Bornstein on Protestant NGOs in Zimbabwe as ethnographic base, Lamin Sanneh on West African religious institutional history as historical base, John Mbiti on African religious philosophy as theoretical base, Séverine Deneulin on religion and human development in the capabilities frame as evaluative base, contemporary reporting on Samaritan's Purse USAID partnership funding and Operation Christmas Child as operational base, and the Code of Conduct 1994 together with the Sphere Standards as normative base, none of which requires more evidence to establish what all of them, taken together, have already established.

The sector's usual response to a finding of this shape is to commission another study or convene another stakeholder dialogue, of which the word for either move is delay ; the alternative, which this Practitioner's Read has consistently pointed at across every issue in the series, is that a country office or a foundation programme officer with the authority to fund a small pilot uses the measurement instrument to read the aid-transaction dynamic in one corridor, funds a community-designed non-conditional channel, and lets the same instrument read whether the shift has held, thereby producing empirical evidence of the direction of change rather than yet another convening on the direction of the debate.

The research was never the hard part.

The choice is.

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Issue 09 of The Practitioner's Read is above.

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VIII.

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